

NEW HOMECOMING
The entrance at the Kuno National Park. Newly translocated cheetahs are the main point of interest, though lions, too, are represented

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about two fatal attacks each year, the sharp increase in the number of attacks itself has alarmed the local population and forest officers.

Srivastav, however, says that the human-lion conflict is not a serious concern as the lion is an "intelligent animal and can coexist with humans". "Humans are attacked as lions mistake them for prey, like when sleeping kids were dragged away or women cutting grass were attacked," he adds. The Gujarat government, he claims, has plans to engage with local communities and spread awareness about lion behaviour. "We are acquiring tracts of wasteland and creating a safe lion corridor in districts like Bhavnagar, Amreli, Botad and Surendranagar," says Srivastav.

Wildlife expert Revtubha Raizada, who conducts awareness camps on how to coexist with lions in Keshod in Junagadh, thinks humans are to blame for the lion attacks. "There is a way to behave when one comes face to face with lions and we regularly conduct workshops on the topic," he says. Wildlife activist Rajan Joshi says there is a shortage of ground staff in the forest department. "This leads to ineffective monitoring of lions, thus people are not alerted," he adds.

The rise in human deaths due to lion attacks is the proverbial tip of the iceberg, though. As their population rises, lions are walking out of protected forest areas into peri-urban areas and agricultural land. Prides of lions

THE PROPOSED TRANSLOCATION OF LIONS IN KUNO IS A THREAT TO CHEETAHS THERE, THE UNION MINISTRY TOLD THE SUPREME COURT IN MARCH

sauntering through small Saurashtra towns have become a common sight. In 2010, with a population of 411, the lions roamed over 20,000 sq. km. Today, with numbers touching 700, they range over 30,000 sq. km in the Saurashtra peninsula spanning nine districts—Junagadh, Amreli, Porbandar, Rajkot, Bhavnagar, Jamnagar, Gir Somnath, Botad and Surendranagar. It's a clear sign that Gir's carrying capacity—the maximum sustainable numbers of a species in a specific environment—for lions is saturated.

Rampant industrial activity in the Saurashtra region as also the ever-spreading tentacles of rail connectivity are not leaving the lions with any undisturbed sanctuary. There are 14 ports on the Saurashtra coastline. During the monsoon of 2022, five lions created a scare at Pipavav Port as they sauntered on the premises late at night. CCTV grabs showed a terrified security guard locking himself in his cabin. Later, the lions were captured and released in Gir. Pipavav has its own broad gauge railway connectivity. Plans are afoot to enhance the capacity of other ports, which will require better rail and road connectivity. This translates to more highways and rail tracks passing through existing lion habitats around Gir. In 2019, the state government admitted to the Gujarat High Court that a stretch of the Pipavav-Surendranagar line passes through lion habitat in Amreli district. It said it had constructed chain-link fencing around some stretches of the track. However, at least one male lion died in 2022 after jumping over the fence.

In 2018, the Gujarat High Court took suo motu cognizance of high unnatural lion deaths resulting from accidents like train hits and electrocution. Amicus curiae Hemang Shah says the matter is not disposed of as the scope has expanded to ensuring the lions' welfare and habitat management. "I have raised the issue of illegal mining and conversion of narrow to broad gauge railway tracks in protected areas, getting the government to admit lion deaths due to CDV and ensuring they are vaccinated and collared for monitoring," Shah says. Indeed, a big concern with the entire population of lions concentrated in one region is that an outbreak of infectious disease could cause significant casualties. In 1994, an outbreak of CDV killed around 1,000 of the 3,000 lions at the Serengeti National Park in Tanzania. Between 2018 and 2020, at least 48 lions died due to CDV and later Babesiosis in Gujarat.

Outside protected areas, there is no consistent prey base for the lions, which leads to attacks on livestock. At least one human death took place when a man was trying to save his goat from a lion. There are natural disasters too—in the 2015 Saurashtra floods, 12 lions were killed in Amreli.

Increasing human population, the concomitant rise in economic activity and industrialisation in Gujarat's lion habitats are brushing against an increase in lion numbers. The solution lies in collaborative effort, not standing on pride. ■